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February 5, 2026

Re: Dima Vaido

Dear Members of the 2026 UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award Committee,

It is my distinct pleasure to nominate **Dima Vaido** for a UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award. I am a Distinguished Professor in the Department of Chemistry & Biochemistry and Materials Science & Engineering, and I serve as Faculty Director of Education for the California NanoSystems Institute (CNSI). In these roles, I have worked closely with many graduate students in both traditional teaching and innovative outreach settings. On rare occasions, a student's contributions are so exceptional that they merit special recognition; Dima is one such individual.

Dima has been a dedicated and integral member of the CNSI Nanoscience Education Program, demonstrating extraordinary commitment, creativity, and leadership. He has played a pivotal role in nearly every aspect of our program, which aims to bring cutting-edge nanoscience education to the greater Los Angeles community. Dima's most traditional teaching role involves serving as a TA for Chem-8, a summer-sessions course for high-school students in nanoscience and entrepreneurship. TAs for this class have unique freedom for curricular design, and Dima has been an outstanding leader who has shaped the class in exciting new ways over the past four years, raising the program's academic rigor and inclusivity through thoughtful curriculum development, clear instruction, and strong peer collaboration.

Beyond the classroom, Dima has been instrumental in our free, hands-on workshops for elementary-, middle-, and high-school teachers, helping to equip teachers with the background, pedagogy, and materials needed to implement nanoscience experiments in their classrooms. To date, the program has served more than 650 teachers from over 240 schools across 60 public school districts in Southern California, with over 70% of participants coming from Title-I schools. These teachers, in turn, reach thousands of students each year. Dima has served as an outstanding lead instructor for countless teacher workshops. He has also worked tirelessly to develop innovative hands-on experiments that translate complex scientific concepts into accessible and engaging learning experiences. One notable example is his work on a new experiment, "Swimming at the Nanoscale," which introduces principles of fluid dynamics and particle motion in a way that is approachable for general audiences. This experiment will debut this Spring, reaching ~1,000 students.

Dima is a mainstay of our public outreach efforts, repeatedly volunteering his time for science fairs, school visits, and community events. His enthusiasm not only excites public participants, but also inspires new volunteers, amplifying his impact well beyond his own contributions. Dima's mentorship further extends to the CNSI Nanovation competition, where he has guided diverse student teams through the intersection of science and entrepreneurship. His ability to motivate students across age groups and experience levels has resulted in outstanding learning experiences for all mentees.

Beyond CNSI, Dima serves as a TA consultant in his home department of Physics and Astronomy, further demonstrating his dedication to teaching excellence.

Dima Vaido exemplifies UCLA's highest standards of teaching, mentorship, and service. For his profound and sustained impact on science education at UCLA and throughout the greater Los Angeles community, I offer my strongest recommendation for this award.

Sincerely,

Sarah Tolbert

Sarah H. Tolbert
Distinguished Professor
Charles and Carolyn Knobler Endowed Chair
Department of Chemistry and Biochemistry
Department of Materials Science and Engineering

Nominee Statement

My passion for teaching is rooted in a desire to make physics accessible, inclusive, and exciting for students who often approach the subject with anxiety or self-doubt. Physics has a reputation for being unrelatable and intimidating, and many students enter introductory courses believing that success depends on innate ability rather than effort and effective learning strategies. In my role as a teaching assistant, I have worked to counter this narrative by creating a learning environment where students believe they can succeed through hard work and perseverance.

My work on developing a growth mindset in my students has focused on fostering a classroom culture that reduces anxiety and encourages active participation. From my earliest quarters as a teaching assistant, I made an effort to normalize asking questions and treat mistakes as learning opportunities. I regularly ask students to share incomplete solutions and refine their thinking with directing questions. My goal is to build confidence in students' ability to engage with difficult material. Student feedback consistently describes me as approachable, encouraging, and supportive, suggesting that these practices have helped students feel comfortable participating and asking questions.

In addition to cultivating supportive environments, I have focused on helping students navigate the overwhelming amount of information commonly seen in physics courses. Introductory physics courses present students with a large volume of material, such as variables and equations, many of which apply only in narrow contexts. To help students organize their learning, I developed concise study guides, formula sheets, and clearly annotated solution sets that highlight core ideas and common misconceptions. For especially challenging topics, I created short review videos that students could revisit at their own pace. Many students reported that these resources helped them plan their studying more effectively and feel less overwhelmed.

As my teaching experience grew, I shifted my focus toward incorporating more active learning. I developed a consistent format built on collaborative worksheets containing two to three carefully sequenced problems. Students begin by working individually, then collaborate in small groups, and finally join a whole-class discussion where we compare solutions and clarify reasoning. This structure, which follows a think-pair-share model, is one of my main teaching tools and has been critical in helping students learn how to approach physics problems.

In addition to regular teaching appointments, I have worked to improve teaching culture at the departmental level. For the past four years, I have served as a Teaching Assistant Consultant in the Department of Physics and Astronomy, working closely with Professor Joshua Samani to train and mentor new teaching assistants. In this role, I helped redesign Physics 495 (Teaching College Physics) to be more interactive and aligned with evidence-based pedagogy. One example of the new structure is the attached "Prediction as a Teaching Tool" assignment, which asks students to design lessons that expose misconceptions and promote peer discussion through structured prediction and reflection. In this course, I focused on modeling effective teaching practices rather than simply describing them. Each class was structured using the same strategies I encouraged TAs to adopt, with the goal of helping them transfer these

practices into their own classrooms. Student feedback indicates that this modeling was memorable and impactful, equipping new TAs with tools to better support their students.

My teaching commitment also extends beyond the physics department. For the past four summers, I have been an instructor in the Applications of Nanoscience (Chemistry 8) at the California NanoSystems Institute (CNSI), where I taught a two-week intensive course for high school students combining science with entrepreneurship. I developed course curriculum, including modules on data analysis and AI, and guided student teams as they developed and pitched science-based product ideas. This experience strengthened my ability to teach across disciplines and reinforced the importance of teamwork and collaboration. I have also participated in CNSI education workshops for K-12 teachers, supporting educators across the Greater Los Angeles area in implementing hands-on nanoscience labs. As part of this work, I developed a new experiment for high school students that teaches how microorganisms perceive their environment, providing valuable experience distilling a complex physics topic for a younger audience.

Across all of my teaching roles, I strive to create environments where students feel supported, challenged, and empowered to succeed. I view this award as recognition of teaching grounded in care, reflection, and a sustained commitment to student learning.

Statement of Teaching Philosophy

My teaching philosophy is grounded in three core commitments: fostering a growth mindset in every student, developing students' critical thinking and problem solving skills, and aligning teaching practices with evidence from educational research. I believe my teaching should help students not just develop the understanding of the material, but also grow confidence and a sense of belonging.

First, I think it is crucial that my students feel they belong. Physics often carries a reputation for difficulty that can discourage participation and reinforce fixed mindsets. In my classroom, I work to cultivate an environment where questions are welcomed and confusion is treated as a natural part of learning. I explicitly emphasize that every mistake is a learning opportunity. By validating student effort and curiosity, I aim to shift attention away from performance and toward growth. My goal is for students to feel comfortable asking questions and trying out any problems without worrying that they might not be able to solve them right away.

Second, I believe that learning is inherently an active and social process. Students develop understanding by wrestling with ideas, articulating their reasoning, and refining their thinking through feedback and discussion. As a result, my teaching emphasizes collaborative problem solving and structured peer interaction rather than passive listening. A central feature of my discussion sections is a consistent workflow built around worksheets containing two to three carefully sequenced problems. Students first work individually, then discuss their ideas in small groups, and finally engage in whole-class discussion where different solution strategies are compared, evaluated, and refined. This iterative process closely mirrors the think-pair-share model supported by physics education research and helps students externalize their thinking while learning from one another. By repeatedly engaging in this cycle, students develop essential critical thinking and problem-solving skills, learning not just how to arrive at an answer, but how to justify their reasoning and adapt their approach in response to new ideas. The "share" portion also allows me to guide the flow of the class and ensure that students leave with a correct understanding of key concepts.

[?] An important principle underlying the design of my worksheets is scaffolding. Early in a lesson, I often provide support such as formula sheets, guiding questions, or partially worked examples to reduce extraneous cognitive load and help students focus on core ideas. As students gain confidence and familiarity, I gradually remove these supports to encourage recall, synthesis, and independent reasoning. This reflects my broader belief that effective instruction meets students where they are while maintaining high expectations for their learning. An attached worksheet from Physics 115C illustrates this approach. The problems guide students from a familiar topic (non-degenerate perturbation theory) toward more subtle techniques they will use later in the course. The first problem motivates the need for new tools, while subsequent problems allow students to practice applying them. The formula sheet at the end is there to help them if they are stuck. This structured scaffolding enables students to productively engage with challenging material while building the confidence needed for effective problem solving.

Third, I believe that my lesson planning should be evidence-based. I regularly draw on education research, student feedback, and discussions with colleagues to inform my instructional choices. My work as a Teaching Assistant Consultant has been especially influential in shaping this aspect of my philosophy. Through redesigning Physics 495 (Teaching College Physics), I have engaged deeply with pedagogical strategies such as prediction questions, retrieval practice, and concreteness fading. The “Prediction as a Teaching Tool” assignment that I have attached explores one of these strategies, in which students design lessons that intentionally reveal misconceptions and connect abstract concepts to observable outcomes. By embedding these practices into TA training, I aim to improve learning experiences not only in my own classrooms but across the department.

Accessibility and flexibility are also central to my teaching philosophy. Students bring diverse backgrounds and life circumstances into the classroom, and I do my best to design instruction that accounts for this diversity. I provide multiple ways for students to engage with material, including recorded discussions, written summaries, and supplemental videos that can be revisited as needed. These resources help lower barriers for students who may not always be able to participate synchronously and support all students in reviewing difficult topics at their own pace. I frame office hours as a welcoming and collaborative space where we work through challenges together. This approach reinforces the idea that learning is an ongoing process supported by reflection, feedback, and persistence.

Ultimately, my goal as an educator is to help students leave my courses with both stronger conceptual understanding and greater confidence in their ability to tackle challenging problems. I want students to recognize that success in physics, and in learning more broadly, is built on persistence, collaboration, and thoughtful reflection rather than innate ability alone. Teaching is an evolving practice, and I remain committed to continually learning from my students, from research, and from colleagues to better support student learning in every role I take on.

Physics 115C - Week 3 - Worksheet

Name:_____ UID:_____

1. Consider the following Hamiltonian:

$$H(\lambda) = H^{(0)} + \lambda H' = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} + \lambda \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$$

This simple problem is designed to motivate the development of a new mathematical tool (the degenerate perturbation theory)

1.1. Find the first-order correction to the energies of the eigenstates of the original Hamiltonian $H^{(0)}$ using non-degenerate perturbation theory.

I first ask the students to approach this problem using a method they learned in the previous weeks (the non-degenerate perturbation theory)

1.2. Find the exact eigenstates of the full Hamiltonian H as well as the corresponding energies. Do you see any discrepancies between this result and the result from part (a)? If yes, what do you think is the reason for that?

In the second part, the students will discover a mismatch between their result in Part 1 and the correct (exact) answer, motivating the development of a new tool

2. Consider the following Hamiltonian:

$$H(\lambda) = H^{(0)} + \lambda H'$$
$$= \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 3 \end{pmatrix} + \lambda \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$$

This is a simple problem that allows the students to make sense of how this new tool works

2.1. Find the first-order correction to the energies of the eigenstates of the original Hamiltonian $H^{(0)}$ using perturbation theory.

In the first part, the students are asked to apply the new method

2.2. Now solve the problem exactly and compare your results to part (a).

In the second part, they compare their results to the exact answer. Unlike the first problem, this time the answer they get is correct

3. Consider the following Hamiltonian:

$$\hat{H} = \hat{H}_0 + \hat{H}'$$
$$\hat{H}_0 = \frac{\hat{p}_x^2 + \hat{p}_y^2}{2m} + \frac{1}{2}k\left(\hat{x}^2 + \hat{y}^2\right)$$
$$\hat{H}' = k'\hat{x}\hat{y}$$

The last problem asks them to apply this new method to a slight more challenging scenario

Calculate the first-order correction to the first two excited states. Note that they are degenerate if $k' = 0$.

This is an opportunity for the students to further practice the concept they have just learned. While the is problem is a bit more challenging, it can be solved using the same method as Problem 2. The motivation for changing the setting is to encourage the transfer of knowledge.

Formula Sheet

Harmonic Oscillator

$$\hat{H} = \frac{1}{2m}\hat{p}^2 + \frac{\hbar\omega}{2}\hat{x}^2$$

$$\hat{x} = \sqrt{\frac{\hbar}{2m\omega}}\,(\hat{a}_+ + \hat{a}_-)$$

$$\hat{a}_+|n\rangle = \sqrt{n+1}|n+1\rangle$$

$$\hat{H}|n\rangle = E_n|n\rangle =$$

I often append a formula sheet to my discussion worksheets. The idea here is to provide the necessary resources so the students can focus on their worksheet without the need to check their computer or their textbook. However, I always put it on a separate page and encourage the students to recall these formulas as much as they can as it is beneficial for their long term memory

Nondegenerate Perturbation Theory

$$\text{First-order energy correction: } E_i^{(1)} = \langle\Psi_i^{(0)}|H'|\Psi_i^{(0)}\rangle$$

$$\text{First-order state correction: } |\Psi_i^{(1)}\rangle = \sum_{j\neq i}|\Psi_j^{(0)}\rangle\frac{\langle\Psi_j^{(0)}|H'|\Psi_i^{(0)}\rangle}{E_i^{(0)} - E_j^{(0)}}$$

Degenerate Perturbation Theory

Consider a subspace of k states with the same energy $E_{i-1}^{(0)} < E_i^{(0)} = E_{i+1}^{(0)} = \ldots = E_{i+k-1}^{(0)} < E_{i+k}^{(0)}$. In order to find the "good" states, we can construct a matrix W, where the entries are $W_{lm} = \langle\Psi_l^{(0)}|H'|\Psi_m^{(0)}\rangle$ for all $l, m \in 1, 2, \ldots, k$. Next, we find the eigenvalues and eigenvectors of the matrix W, which will tell us what are the "good" states and what are the energy corrections to them.

Let's demonstrate how it works in a simple example when $k = 2$:

$$W = \begin{pmatrix} \langle\Psi_i^{(0)}|H'|\Psi_i^{(0)}\rangle & \langle\Psi_i^{(0)}|H'|\Psi_{i+1}^{(0)}\rangle \\ \langle\Psi_{i+1}^{(0)}|H'|\Psi_i^{(0)}\rangle & \langle\Psi_{i+1}^{(0)}|H'|\Psi_{i+1}^{(0)}\rangle \end{pmatrix}$$

Suppose that the first eigenvalue of W is μ_1 with the corresponding eigenvector $\vec{v}_{\mu_1} = \begin{pmatrix} a_1 \\ b_1 \end{pmatrix}$, and the second eigenvalue is μ_2 with $\vec{v}_{\mu_2} = \begin{pmatrix} a_2 \\ b_2 \end{pmatrix}$. Then the "good" states are given by:

$$|\Psi_I\rangle = a_1|\Psi_i^{(0)}\rangle + b_1|\Psi_{i+1}^{(0)}\rangle \text{ and } |\Psi_{II}\rangle = a_2|\Psi_i^{(0)}\rangle + b_2|\Psi_{i+1}^{(0)}\rangle$$

And μ_1 and μ_2 are then the first order energy corrections $E_I^{(1)}$ and $E_{II}^{(1)}$ correspondingly. Here we assumed that $\mu_1 \neq \mu_2$, meaning that the perturbation is breaking the degeneracy at the first order. Once the degeneracy is broken, we can calculate all the higher-order corrections using the nondegenerate perturbation theory.

Hint for Problem 3: Start by writing $\hat{x}$ and $\hat{y}$ in terms of the corresponding ladder operators:

$$\hat{x} = \sqrt{\frac{\hbar}{2m\omega_0}}\,(\hat{a}_+ + \hat{a}_-)$$

$$\hat{y} = \sqrt{\frac{\hbar}{2m\omega_0}}\left(\hat{b}_+ + \hat{b}_-\right)$$

where $\omega_0 = \sqrt{k/m}$.

Name:_____

Name:_____

Name:_____

Name:_____

This is a microteaching assignment which asks our students to implement a specific engagement tool (asking for predictions)

Introduction

Asking students to make a prediction is a powerful teaching tool that, when implemented well, can have many benefits including:

- Exposing misconceptions
  - Once exposed, they can be corrected with appropriate feedback
- Surprising the learner
  - This can be both engaging, and impactful for long-term retention (i.e learners tend to remember something surprising better especially if it subverts confidently-held beliefs)
- Motivating people to work together
  - When something seems simple but is actually tricky, having someone to talk to can feel really helpful
- Demonstrating how science works
  - i.e. the centrality in science of comparing experimental results to theoretical predictions as a means of testing and revising theories

Maybe you can think of others? When we refer to an "effective" prediction question, we mean one that in practice results in some of the bullet points listed above (or others others that one might articulate and that align with one's objectives).

Your task

In this assignment, you're asked to work in a team to select a physical scenario with some non-obvious behavior, write a question that involves students making a prediction about that behavior, and lead a think-pair-share in which students not only make the prediction, but grapple with how to make sense of the correct physical behavior.

We will randomly select two teams to present their prediction + think-pair-share lesson with the class.

You will have 15 minutes to present.

To complete this assignment, answer the prompts using the space provided on the following pages:

1. What are the learning objectives for this prediction activity? In other words, what do you want students to be able to do better after they complete it?

In all of our microteaching assignments we ask the students to state their objectives. The aim is to nurture the objective-oriented approach to developing lesson plans.

2. State your description of the physical scenario, and then state your prediction question. Is your question free response or multiple choice – which format did you choose and why? What learning objectives does your choice serve?

We ask students to state their design choices. This is an important step that asks them to step back and reflect on their lesson plan.

3. Ideally when asking a prediction question, you'd pick something that you can physically demonstrate in class, but we recognize that this may not be logistically possible. Explain how you intend to reveal the correct behavior (e.g. maybe there's a simulation or video you can show, or maybe it's enough to carefully apply physical principles at the board).

With both of these items we aim to set the bar on the level of preparation that we expect from them in a real classroom.

4. Describe at what point students will be asked to "think," at what point will they be asked to "pair," and at what point they will be asked to "share." Recall that the "share" step refers to sharing with the whole class. How much time will you give students for each step? After which step will you reveal the correct behavior to compare to student predictions? Why did you make these choices? In what way do you believe you design choices will help accomplish your objectives or make the prediction task effective? (more space on the next page).

Selected Written Comments from Student Experiences of Teaching Reports

Cumulative Statistics (N = 179, accumulated over 14 courses, reported as mean ± st.dev.)

Teaching assistance knowledge:	8.60 ± 0.68
Teaching assistant concern:	8.76 ± 0.58
Organization:	8.52 ± 0.94
Scope:	8.58 ± 0.78
Interaction:	8.73 ± 0.70
Communication skills:	8.71 ± 0.60
Value:	8.51 ± 1.04
Overall:	8.74 ± 0.59

Student 1 (Physics 5C Discussion - Physics for Life Sciences Majors III)

Dima cared so much about us students! I genuinely feel as though I got to know him and he got to know me. He took time to create extra resources for us students because he knew we were struggling with the format of this class. I appreciated the explanation sheets that he made for us because they were great summaries/ examples of content covered in the class. He was great at explaining the weekly problems that we went over in class and was super helpful with the understanding of course content. He had a warm personality and was very knowledgeable. A great combination!

Dima is such an awesome individual and he really created an atmosphere that fostered collaboration. He was very approachable and always had me chucking in sections with his honesty. Loved the mini lectures and I especially appreciated how Dima went above and beyond to try and see where he maybe could do better for us and with our section being his only I felt that we were really supported. He answered all questions we had and even encouraged us to ask them. He has been really gracious and extremely helpful with making formula sheets and videos discussing the material and weekly discussion solutions as well as uploading the mini review/lecture from section. If you were needing help, Dima is definitely someone who could go to and I'm so happy that I got to have him as my TA. All around amazing job this quarter and cannot thank him enough for all that he's done for us.

Student 2 (Physics 5C Discussion - Physics for Life Sciences Majors III)

Dima is an amazing TA. His sections were always highly organized. The first ten minutes were review of lecture material and always came with a summarized equation/concepts sheet, and this first ten minutes were always streamed on Zoom and uploaded for later access. Then we would dive into the discussion worksheet. Sections were optional but I went to every single one, as well as Dima's office hours which followed right after. I loved going to office hours in order get clarifications on concepts or have him walk me through certain problems. He was always very understanding, patient, knowledgeable, and very effective at teaching. He also hosted a review session before our midterm which was of great help. Dima is truly amazing and I would select him as my TA again in a heartbeat.

Dima is an excellent TA! I struggled to understand lectures, so his discussion sections were instrumental to my success in the course. He was very approachable and committed to making us feel comfortable asking him questions. He went above and beyond to provide help via email for students who were unable to attend his office hours. I am very appreciative of the notes he created to share with us too!

Student 3 (Physics 1BH Discussion - Physics for Scientists and Engineers II (Honors))

Dima was extremely helpful throughout the quarter, especially in such a fast-paced honors course. I found the review notesheets that Dima would upload about important topics helpful in streamlining my study process, and Dima's solution sets and notes were always neat and well-organized. Additionally, Dima was always so enthusiastic and open to answer our questions in discussion, and he explained topics very concisely. I really appreciate all that you do; thanks so much Dima!

Student 4 (Physics 1CH Discussion - Physics for Scientists and Engineers III (Honors))

Dima went above and beyond his role in order to make sure we were able to learn the material. If a lecture left the class confused and uncertain about something (which happened quite often), Dima would record his own video discussing the topic or find resources online and direct us to them so we could better understand what we were being taught. I always felt welcome to reach out to him with questions and received answers very shortly after I asked them. Dima did an incredible amount of work so we could do better, and was by far the best TA I have had.

Student 5 (Physics 115C Discussion - Quantum Mechanics III)

Dima (he went by this name) is one of my favorite TA's I have ever had. He is honestly a bit of an inspiration for myself because I want to go into education and approach it with the same compassion and support does. Dima always knew what was going on in the class and was honest with us about what was hard and what was not as hard. He always let us know when he thought a problem was sneaky or unfair (happens a lot in quantum mechanics). Moreover, he set up a campuswire for the class (prof did not seem to be involved at all) which he was always checking for questions. He also responded to emails quickly and thoroughly. All this would already put him miles ahead of most other TA's and professors here in my book, but Dima was also a funny and genuine person; he felt like a real human who cared about us not as a means to an end (to fulfill his responsibilities as a TA or something) but as other people who were passionate about the same subject he is. There was one instance where he personally emailed me after office hours about a small thing he forgot to say and encouraged me to ask him if I had any questions at all. I got so much more out of this course because of Dima.

Student 6 (Physics 115C Discussion - Quantum Mechanics III)

Dima was very helpful in giving us problems that expanded on the conceptual ideas from class and giving us some practice of how to use it all in practice. It's hard to strike a balance between lecturing on the material to ensure when students start the practice they know what to do and giving ample time to do the practice, and sometimes that balance was a little off, but I think it generally always worked out to be helpful. Overall, Dima's discussions were consistently useful

for bridging the gap between the lecture and homework, and I hope he keeps up that format in future classes!

I thought Dima was a very good TA, and I really liked how he already typed up the problem sets for discussion. I really enjoy how he gives us some time to work on the problems, and then goes through the solutions. I think the discussion sections really helped me actually apply what I learned in lecture. He always gave pretty relevant questions.

Student 7 (Physics 495 Seminar - Teaching College Physics)

Thank you for bringing innovative ideas into P495 and grooming us to become effective TAs. Ferpa was amazing and surprising. Cultural difference is really a thing and it was nice to get to know about US education system and responsibilities and duties of TA.

What better way to learn how to be an amazing TA than taking a course from one.

Student 8 (Physics 495 Seminar - Teaching College Physics)

I thought the material presented in this course was very valuable, especially because it is something that almost none of the incoming physics grad students had prior knowledge in. It is very important that we learn how to be good TAs and instructors, and I think this course did a great job of introducing both teaching strategies and their pedagogical justification. I think the instructor did a great job of practicing what he preached: he engaged well with students, listened to our input, and employed teaching strategies that would help us learn the material better.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Dima brings a strong passion for physics and science to all of his teaching, no matter who his audience is. I believe this is particularly impactful when teaching high school students and when trying to engage the public in science (which he has done through the above mentioned CNSI programs) as physics is often a subject that folks may feel disconnected from. In his courses at UCLA, Dima has done the same, trying to make his physics classrooms more inclusive and encouraging active learning and participation. He has a way of making the content feel relatable and explaining very clearly why it's important and how it does relate to students' lives. While I have never been one of Dima's students, I can imagine that this is a very impactful experience for them, helping them get excited about the material and potentially inspiring them to continue in physics or other scientific fields. Dima has also dedicated significant time to not just improving himself as a TA, but improving his department and aligning coursework with evidence-based pedagogical techniques and making it more interactive. This highlights Dima's dedication to teaching, continuing to grow and improve on both personal and departmental levels.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

In the Applications of Nanoscience course, Dima helped develop an interactive workshop focused on the use of AI in the classroom. In the first part of the workshop Dima noted the best cases for using AI and general tips and tricks that would be helpful for students to know. The second part focused on challenges and issues associated with AI. In this section, Dima showed students studies about the level of brain activity associated with using chatGPT and showing scientific papers that describe how using AI affects critical thinking. In this way, Dima sought to highlight that AI can be a useful tool but also has its drawbacks and that students must be critical when using it. Additionally, I have seen Dima incorporate active learning and participation strategies to help engage students and get them thinking about the material at hand. Because of his consistent enthusiasm for science, it has always seemed to me that students are more than happy to participate when he is supporting them. To me this is both very impressive and highlights just how impactful and effective an educator he is.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name Dzmitry Vaido

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

I took a graduate teaching course in the Physics & Astronomy Department where Dima was the TA/instructor.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Dima plays an instrumental role in the course as he works alongside the professor to design and deliver the classes, and the effort he puts into improving the teaching culture in the department is highly appreciated.

The course was structured as 1-hour discussions per week, with assignments ranging from grading mock homeworks on Gradescope, to creating lesson plans, recording and evaluating our own discussions, and attending each others' sections. During the class time, Dima and the professor would give a short lecture and then facilitate discussion on the assignments of the previous week.

Throughout the course, Dima successfully maintained a highly interactive and collaborative environment among the ~20 first year graduate students, where we felt comfortable to discuss and share our ideas within groups first and then with the whole class. I believe that his commitment to practice what he preaches by modeling active learning techniques and centering student engagement played a huge part in motivating students to put in the work for the class and in future teaching duties.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

As someone who learns best with examples, Dima's activity-based approach helped me understand the course content better. After giving brief overviews of certain evidence-based teaching techniques, we would test out the methods on each other so we could experience them from both the perspective of a student and the instructor. Dima did a great job facilitating the activities while allowing us to explore our own styles and build upon the concepts introduced in the class.

Another beneficial thing was Dima's emphasis on self-reflection and the way he guided the class to effectively give, receive, and act on feedback. One of the activities that impacted me a lot was comparing peer feedback with our self evaluation. It really helped to understand the limits, accuracy, and biases in my self perception and be able to devise concrete plans for improvement under the guidance of Dima and the professor. The way he led us to identify issues, pose hypotheses to fix them, and test out our solutions stuck with me and helped me navigate teaching beyond the course.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

I believe that Dima is very deserving of this award because of his commitment to improving education throughout the department. During the course, he was extremely present, established great rapport with his students, and made sure everyone felt heard and included. Beyond the class, he remembers his students and shows genuine care for their progress, be it in terms of teaching or in the program in general. Dima is a very important role model and mentor in the department.

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February 8, 2026

Dear Committee on Teaching,

I am delighted to recommend Dzmitry (Dima) Vaido for the Distinguished Teaching Award.

I have extensive experience interacting with Dima both in the instructional design process and in teaching in the classroom. Dima has served as TAC for Physics 495 (TA training) for four years. We have worked closely together to improve Physics 495 over those iterations, and I we have co-taught the course, so I've directly observed his classroom teaching across years.

Dima is unique in my experience working with TAs at UCLA. He has extensive knowledge of the scholarly literature on teaching and learning, a lot of teaching experience, and a deep, genuine desire to improve science education. This is a rare combination, and it is why I originally recruited him to be the 495 TAC – I was looking for someone who could meaningfully work with me to improve the course, and Dima has not disappointed.

The first major change to 495 that Dima and collaboratively made was changing the structure of 495 so that it now contains a two-day pre-quarter teaching bootcamp in addition to our weekly meetings during the fall quarter. Although we co-designed and implemented most of the elements of this bootcamp, Dima was the principal designer and teacher of sessions on giving productive feedback to peers and aligning on the goals of 495 in small teams. Another element that Dima made significant contributions to was the design and implementation of the second day of the bootcamp in which students completed microteaching assignments in teams. In all of these cases, previous iterations of 495 did not have well-structured materials that were thoughtfully designed to best accomplish the course's learning objectives, but in collaborating with Dima, the current iteration of these materials has become strong in this regard.

The following is a list of other elements of 495 to which Dima has made significant contributions both in original implementation and the process of continuous improvement:

1. The development of reflection worksheets for every 495 class session that transformed sessions into active, interactive, vibrant learning experiences.
2. A session on grading with discipline-based guidance and discussion of rubric design.
3. Formalized observations and feedback of TAs who are teaching during 495
4. Sessions on practical implementation of prediction and concreteness fading – two pedagogical techniques particularly well-suited to leading interactive physics discussion sections.

Dima has been a superstar TAC in every sense of the word. Our discussions about the 495 course structure and improvements guided by experiences, learning objectives, and the literature on education and human learning have been exceedingly productive, leading to a much improved 495 course over the past four years. His deep desire to improve science education comes through in all of his interactions with me and with students. He is an excellent teacher with great technique in leading an interactive

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classroom. He is a compassionate educator who insists on making sure student feedback and needs are acted upon. It will be very hard to find a suitable replacement for him as 495 TAC after he graduates.

Dima is an exceptional candidate for this award, and I recommend him strongly and without hesitation. He is the sort of educator we would do well to encourage and invest in.

Dr. Joshua Samani



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